

neighbours PAKISTAN

By storming the Lal Masjid, Musharraf may have won the battle, but the war with the radical Mullahs has just begun

■ By Muhammad Najeeb in Islamabad

Already embroiled in a political mess of his own making, Pakistan President General Pervez Musharraf now faces a ferocious Islamist backlash a day after he ordered his security forces to storm Islamabad's Lal Masjid and flush out the militants who had held the complex hostage for over a week. The military action, codenamed 'Operation Silence', was anything but that. It left more than 150 militants dead including Abdul Rashid Ghazi, the hardline deputy administrator of the Masjid. So fierce was the fighting that 15 armymen were also killed in the gun battle.

Musharraf's detractors, particularly the leaders of religious parties and clerical elite, say the bloodshed that turned the mosque red could have been avoided had the President given negotiations a chance and shown a bit of flexibility. While mystery shrouds the reality of backdoor negotiations that were said to have continued until moments before army's elite troopers were let loose on the holed-up militants, protests have erupted all over the country to avenge the killing of Ghazi and his radical followers who had launched a Taliban-style campaign in February this year for the implementation of Islamic laws. Hundreds of demonstrators in Peshawar, chanting slogans against Musharraf and the US, swore to draw their revenge from the military ruler who came to power in 1999 after booting out a democratically elected Government.

After intelligence reports that extremists may unleash a string of revenge suicide attacks targeting Government installations and functionaries, security forces have been put on high alert in the entire country particularly in North West Frontier Province (NWFP) and Balochistan, bordering Afghanistan, where religious schools have close links with Lal Masjid. Though no Bhindranwale, Ghazi may well be the new martyr of an otherwise low-profile Shariah movement in the country.

The situation becomes even more complex for Musharraf as religious-



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political parties appear to be ready to channelise the public anger and convert it into their political strength ahead of general elections that are due this year or early 2008. The rightwing radical Jamaat-i-Islami's head Qazi Hussain Ahmed has already declared that the Lal Masjid assault has drawn a 'bloodline' between the people and the army. His rather moderate political comrade Jamiat Ulema-i-Islam's head, Maulana Fazlur Rehman, who is also

the leader of the Opposition, appears perturbed and blames the Government for the carnage that took away Islamabad's innocence.

Having a track record of using brute force to crush dissent and justifying it as part of the global war on terror, it is feared that the military-controlled Government will quickly resort to hard-handed tactics to quell the backlash that has only been spreading. Attacks by militants in NWFP last week that